Ent'd July 11 Ack'd

Mr Burlingame Agent

Confidential

No 206 One Enclosure

Legation of the United States
Peking, May 13, 1873

Frederick F Low

to

Department of State

Subject

Japanese Embassy to China.

States that it has reached Peking, and gives an account of the interview between himself and his colleagues and the "Counsellor" of the Embassy touching etiquette; also

also enclosed copy of a letter from Mr Consul Sheppard of Tientsin, in which an account is given of their proceedings while the Embassy was at that place.

Not to be printed

Confidential

No 256 One Enclosure

Legation of the United States
Peking, May 13, 1873.

Sir:-

Herewith I beg to transmit copy of a letter received from Mr Consul Sheppard of Tientsin giving an account of the proceedings of the Japanese Embassy while at that place. It is interesting, and will repay perusal.

After the Embassy closed their business there, they came to Hon Hamilton Fish on Secretary of State

on to Peking; arriving here on the 7th instant. They occupy a Temple in this City about one mile from this Legation.

The morning after their arrival General LeGendre called upon me. He came, he said, as an American citizen to pay his respects to the American Minister. He took particular pains to impress me with the fact that his visit was unofficial; also that he was unprepared to give any information as to the Embassy with which he is connected or its business; to which I replied that I had

had no desire to meddle with the business of the Japanese. If however the Ambassador should at any time need my good offices, I said, it would afford me pleasure to render him such assistance as I could consistently with my other duties. In the course of the conversation I discovered the real object of the General's visit; which was to intimate that the Japanese Ambassador would insist that his superior rank should be recognized by all the ministers here, native and foreign; in other words, that he should expect all the

foreign

foreign representatives, and the Chinese Ministers including Prince Kung, to call upon him.

In response I said that it was extremely doubtful whether such a claim could be made properly; that if made and insisted on it would, most likely, isolate the Ambassador from the other foreign representatives, and prevent all personal intercourse between him and the Chinese Government. I further observed that I was not familiar with any rule of etiquette which would justify an Ambassador in taking rank

over

over as Envoy until after he had been received and recognized by the head of the Government to which he is accredited. But aside from the absolute right and wrong of this case there are strong reasons why the foreign Ministers should not accede to the request. They are now in joint negotiation with the Chinese Government concerning a question that is of great importance to all the Treaty Powers. The business seems now to be in a fair way to an amicable and honorable settlement. Were the Japanese Ambassador

Ambassador to be recognized as the Dean of the diplomatic Body and take part in the negotiations now pending, it would have the effect to reopen the discussion, and this would cause delay which would probably defeat what now seems nearly gained. I concluded by saying that, owing to my present physical infirmities the question of making calls of ceremony could hardly be considered a practical one with me; that the decision concerning the questions raised lay with my colleagues chiefly,

and

and suggested that they be consulted.

The General seemed to be very decided in his opinions; he affirmed with considerable warmth that it would be derogatory to the dignity of the Ambassador were he to recede from the position indicated. In support of his view of the case he referred me to the rules laid down by the Congress of Vienna of 19th March 1815, and to the published account of the reception of Count Fleury as French Ambassador at St Petersburg. He was

also

also so indiscreet as to indulge in a menace, to the effect that in case the foreign Ministers failed to recognize the claims set up by the Ambassador the interests of their governments in Japan would probably be made to suffer for it.

Subsequently the General consulted with the Russian Minister, and through him as well with those of England and France, all of whom most emphatically declined to yield to what they considered an unauthorized assumption put forward by the Ambassador, or his Counsellor, or both.

From

From what the Russian Minister has told me about his interview with General Le Gendre, the latter, I infer, made use of the same arguments and threats that he did in his conversation with me. He also submitted to General Vlangaly a long written memorandum on the subjects, and asked that he and his colleagues would reply to it. No answer has, I hear, been returned nor has any notice been taken of the Generals memorandum.

I may add that Genl Le Gendres action in this matter has made a very unfavorable

unfavorable impression upon my Colleagues; it has evidently increased their jealousy and distrust of him. If he displays no more discretion when dealing with the Chinese Ministers his presence here will do the Japanese much harm I fear.

I have the honor to be
Sir
Your Obedient Servant
Frederick F. Low

P.S.

Since writing the foregoing General Vaughn has called to say that he had just received

received a note from Genl Le Gendre to the effect that, after the Ambassador notifies his presence in Peking to the Chinese Government he will make an unofficial call on the foreign Ministers. He also desires to recall the memorandum before referred to.

F. F. L.

Enclosure

No 1 Mr Consul Sheppard to Mr Low. May 7, 1873

Enclosure N° 1.
Dispatch N° 256.

United States Consulate
Tientsin, May 7th 1873

Hon. Frederick F. Low
U. S. Minister
Peking.

Sir:—

The recent meeting of the Japanese Ambassador with the Viceroy of this Province at Tientsin for the purpose of ratifying the Treaty lately entered into between Japan and China, has attracted so much attention that I beg to lay before you a brief account of the official interchanges which took place between the Ministers of the two countries, together with a few facts and data, connected therewith which I have thought might not be without value to yourself.

Saneomi Soyeshima,

the

the Ambassador Extraordinary from Japan, accompanied by a Japanese Admiral arrived at Takw about the 19th of April. The Flagship which brought the Embassy being unable to cross the Bar anchored outside, and on the day following the American Steamer "Willet" was placed at the disposal of the Ambassador, who, accompanied by his Admiral, Secretary, Interpreter, and Attachés, embarked at once and reached Tientsin at 7 o'clock P. M.

I should mention that C. W. Le Gendre, Esq. late U. S. Consul at Amoy, who is attached to the Embassy in the capacity of Adviser, had reached Tientsin the day previous by the Steamer "Shantung" from Shanghai.

The interest and curiosity which is always excited in the minds of the Chinese by the presence of Japanese in this country, was greatly heightened in this instance

by

by the fact that the Japanese appeared here for the first time in foreign clothes i.e. European costume. Among the lower classes this fact simply provoked good-natured idle curiosity - as all novelty does amongst the simple-minded countrymen. But - amongst the literati and - official classes a very different feeling was plainly manifest.

Two days after their - arrival, the Customs Taotai of Tientsin was deputed to convey to the Ambassador the Viceroy's compliments and assurances of friendly feeling on the part of the Chinese Government - towards Japan, and to arrange for an official interview. An interview between the Ambassador and Li Hung Chang was accordingly arranged to take place at the Viceroy's Yamên on the following day. In due time, the Viceroy with the Customs and the territorial

Taotais

Taotai, and the Prefect of Tientsin, accompanied by a large and imposing retinue returned the Ambassador's visit.

These two visits were ceremonial and preliminary to the final meeting for the exchange and ratification of the Treaty, which took place on the 30th of April, at the Shansi Hui Kuan in the city of Tientsin.

The particulars of what transpired at these several interviews have not, of course, been made public officially. But by reports from Chinese sources I have gathered a few incidents connected therewith which seem worthy of note. Whilst I am satisfied from other sources of information that these reports are substantially correct, I give them to you as matter of report simply, without vouching for their correctness.

General

General Le Gendre, whom I before mentioned as connected with the Embassy was present at each of the two interviews which I have named, as also at the finial meeting of ratification on the 30th of April above mentioned.

It is reported among the Chinese that at the first one of these interviews the Viceroy, after being introduced, inquired of the Ambassador, - "Who is this Foreigner" "What is his business here" or questions to that effect. The Ambassador's answer was that General Le Gendre accompanied the Embassy as Adviser, and that he was here at the request and by the authority of the Japanese Government.

The Viceroy replied that - "we" - meaning the Chinese and Japanese - "have made other treaties before this "one, and we did not find the need "of foreigners to advise us, and what "reason is there for it now"

He

He insisted that he could not recognize General Le Gendre, in any official capacity relating to the Embassy.

At each of the first two interviews named the Viceroy's conduct towards Genl. Le Gendre was studiously cold and uncourteous. At the final meeting on the 30th of April the Viceroy however, saw fit to entirely change his demeanor towards him, and on this occasion his extravagant politeness was only equalled by his former incivility and rudeness.

As far as I have been able to learn, the intercourse between the Ambassador and the Viceroy was pleasant enough. There is, however no disguising the fact that the ruling classes here, including His Excellency the Viceroy, hold the Japanese in sovereign contempt. The adoption of foreign dress and foreign manners

by

by the Japanese has stung almost to exasperation the proud stolid Chinese.

It is deeply to be regretted that Li Hung Chang should have taken advantage of his high official position, as it would seem he has done in this instance to promote and strengthen the exclusive and selfish spirit of distrust of Foreigners, and Foreign influences, so much indulged in by the pompous, conceited, and too often ignorant mandarins.

The Viceroy's ungracious demeanor toward Genl Le Gendre, did not arise, I think, from personal considerations. The fact that the Japanese had seemingly identified themselves with Foreigners by employing a Foreign Adviser, was so entirely at variance with the Viceroy's ideas of Oriental superiority, that he could not resist giving his

cousins

cousins from the "Rising Sun" a left-handed slap for submitting to, or seeking after the guidance of Western Barbarians. This little incident, otherwise unworthy of notice, becomes very significant in view of the recent advances toward modern civilization made by the Japanese, and of the relations between that country and China. It gives, also, one more unhappy proof of the distrust and dislike of Western peoples amongst the ruling classes of China.

Of the nature and conditions of the new Treaty just ratified, nothing has, as yet, transpired.

I am,
Sir,
Your obedient servant,
(Signed) Eli T. Sheppard
U. S. Consul.